

Unit 14: Investigating Customer Service

Level: **3**

Unit type: **Internal**

Guided learning hours: **60**

Unit in brief

Learners will study how excellent customer service contributes to business success. The unit gives learners the opportunity to develop their customer service skills.

Unit introduction

How is excellent customer service linked to business success? In this unit you will learn that attracting new customers costs a business more than keeping existing customers, so it is important to keep existing customers happy. You can do this by building relationships with internal and external customers and giving them excellent service that exceeds their needs and expectations.

When working in a customer service role you need to understand the procedures to follow when dealing with customer requests and complaints. This unit will help you develop communication and interpersonal skills when dealing with customers, and to understand the importance of having good product or service knowledge. You will explore how a business builds effective relationships with customers through identifying and confirming the customer's needs. You will examine how businesses monitor and evaluate their level of customer service provision through obtaining feedback and see how this helps inform improvements to the level of service provided.

The unit will enable you to evaluate your own customer service skills and to create a development plan for improvement. The unit also supports further training, study or employment in a business environment.

Learning aims

In this unit you will:

- A** Explore how effective customer service contributes to business success
- B** Investigate the methods used to improve customer service in a business
- C** Demonstrate customer service skills in different situations, using appropriate behaviours to meet expectations.

Summary of unit

Learning aim	Key content areas	Assessment approach
A Explore how effective customer service contributes to business success	A1 Customer service in business A2 Customer expectations and satisfaction A3 Benefits of building customer relationships A4 Customer service legislation and regulations	A report examining the customer service provision/process in a business and the value of delivering excellent customer service to support business success. Prepare a training handbook for a selected business on customer service, including relevant legislation and regulations. The report should also include monitoring methods used to review the customer service provision and should draw on quantitative and qualitative data.
B Investigate the methods used to improve customer service in a business	B1 Monitoring and evaluating customer service provision B2 Indicators in improved performance	
C Demonstrate customer service skills in different situations, using appropriate behaviours to meet expectations	C1 Customer service skills and behaviours C2 Dealing with customer service requests and complaints C3 Individual skills audit and development plan	Demonstration of customer service skills in at least three different business situations. Focus on a demonstration of product/service knowledge when dealing with customers' queries, requests and problems. An evaluation of skills is also included.

Content

Learning aim A: Explore how effective customer service contributes to business success

A1 Customer service in business

- Definition of customer service.
- Customer service roles and importance of teamwork.
- Importance of following organisational rules and procedures.
- Different approaches to customer service across industries need different skills and knowledge such as:
 - retail shops selling tangible goods – need for detailed product knowledge and effective selling skills
 - offices such as those offering a non-tangible service, either face-to-face with customers, online, written or telephone customer contact
 - contact centres with telephone contact with customers, time limitations
 - hospitality industry such as serving skills for food or drinks.

A2 Customer expectations and satisfaction

- Different types of customer, including:
 - internal and external customers and the differences between them
 - customer personalities such as aggressive, quiet, demanding
 - customers with special requirements, e.g. different language or culture, age, gender, families, special needs such as visual, hearing or mobility.
- Customer complaints.
- Customer expectations and satisfaction, including:
 - anticipation of good service, reliable information or service, offering different options, impact of advertisements, reputation, word of mouth, recommendations from others
 - importance of responding to customer needs, exceeding customer expectations through providing additional help and assistance, dealing promptly with problems, offering discounts, offering additional products or services, providing exceptional help and assistance for customers with special requirements
 - balancing customer satisfaction with business goals, aims and objectives.
- Understanding the risk to the business of not dealing with complaints.

A3 Benefits of building customer relationships

- Enhanced reputation of business.
- Repeat business.
- Customer confidence in business.
- Job satisfaction for employees.

A4 Customer service legislation and regulations

- Industry and sector-specific codes of practice, ethical issues and standards.
- Implications for the business of not meeting all legal and regulatory requirements, including consumer protection, distance selling, sale of goods, health and safety, data protection, equal opportunities.

Learning aim B: Investigate the methods used to improve customer service in a business

B1 Monitoring and evaluating customer service provision

- Using research from customers to identify improvements and monitor complaints.
- Monitoring, using:
 - customer profiles, data, e.g. types of customer, products or services provided, customer care and service
 - sources of information, e.g. customers, colleagues, management
 - methods, e.g. questionnaires, comment cards, quality circles, suggestion boxes, staff surveys, mystery shoppers, recording and sharing information.
- Evaluating customer service, including:
 - analyse responses, e.g. level of customer satisfaction, quality of product or service, meeting regulatory requirements, balancing cost and benefits
 - planning for change, resolving problems/complaints.

B2 Indicators in improved performance

- Reduction in numbers of complaints.
- Increase in profits.
- Reduction in turnover of staff.
- Repeat business from loyal customers.

Learning aim C: Demonstrate customer service skills in different situations, using appropriate behaviours to meet expectations

C1 Customer service skills and behaviours

- Communication skills:
 - face-to-face, written, email or other electronic media, telephone
 - verbal, e.g. pitch and tone of voice, open and closed questions, using the telephone
 - non-verbal, e.g. sign and body language, listening skills
 - barriers to communication.
- Interpersonal skills:
 - personal presentation approach, e.g. attitude, behaviour, hygiene, personality, conversation skills, giving a consistent and reliable response.
- Behaviours, e.g. being positive, offering assistance, showing respect.

C2 Dealing with customer service requests and complaints

- Customer service situations:
 - providing information, products or services, promoting additional products and services, giving advice, taking and relaying messages
 - limitations of role and authority, keeping records
 - dealing with problems, handling complaints, remedial measures, emergency situations, organisational policy.

C3 Individual skills audit and development plan

- Skills audit of customer service skills.
- Personal SWOT (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats) analysis to assess any gaps, e.g. interpersonal and communication skills – body language, listening skills, handling complaints, working with others.
- Set objectives to meet skills development goals for a specified customer services role by:
 - identifying resources and available support needed to meet the objectives
 - setting review dates
 - monitoring the plan to assess progress against targets.

Assessment criteria

Pass	Merit	Distinction
Learning aim A: Explore how effective customer service contributes to business success		A.D1 Evaluate the importance for a selected business of providing excellent customer service and adhering to relevant current legislation and regulations.
A.P1 Describe the different approaches to customer service delivery in contrasting businesses. A.P2 Examine ways that customer service in a selected business can meet the expectations and satisfaction of customers and adhere to relevant current legislation and regulations.	A.M1 Analyse how legislation and regulation impacts on customer service provision in a selected business.	
Learning aim B: Investigate the methods used to improve customer service in a business		B.D2 Evaluate the benefits of improvements to customer service performance for the business, the customer, and the employee.
B.P3 Research methods a business can use to make improvements to the customer service provision.	B.M2 Analyse different methods of monitoring customer service for a product or service in a selected business.	
Learning aim C: Demonstrate customer service skills in different situations, using appropriate behaviours to meet expectations		C.D3 Demonstrate initiative in making high-quality justified recommendations to develop own communication and interpersonal skills to meet customer needs.
C.P4 Demonstrate communication and interpersonal skills appropriate to meet customer needs in different situations. C.P5 Review own customer service skills, identifying gaps where improvements could be made. C.P6 Present a clear, effective development plan for own customer service skills.	C.M3 Assess how the development plan has improved the performance of customer service skills.	

Essential information for assignments

The recommended structure of assessment is shown in the unit summary, along with suitable forms of evidence. *Section 6 Internal assessment* gives information on setting assignments and there is also further information on our website.

There is a maximum number of two summative assignments for this unit.

The relationship of the learning aims and criteria is:

Learning aims: A and B (A.P1, A.P2, B.P3, A.M1, B.M2, A.D1, B.D2)

Learning aim: C (C.P4, C.P5, C.P6, C.M3, C.D3)

Further information for teachers and assessors

Resource requirements

For this unit, learners must have access to a range of current business information from websites and printed resources.

Essential information for assessment decisions

Learning aims A and B

For Distinction standard, learners will prepare evidence based on research.

The report will give details of what is required to ensure that good customer service leads to business success. Examples of how to enhance customer service will be original and imaginative. The evidence will include references to legislation and how a business ensures that customer expectations are exceeded. There will be clear examples of monitoring and how effective customer service can be in ensuring that customers are happy.

The training pack will be high quality with clear detail on all aspects of customer service so that it can be used in practical situations to ensure that employees exceed customer expectations.

For Merit standard, learners will analyse examples of how legislation and regulation impact on customer service. Details of how to make improvements and monitor customer service will be included, with examples of good practice. The training pack created will be to a good standard with relevant practical information and detail to enable the provision of very good customer service.

For Pass standard, learners will prepare evidence that covers the approaches that businesses take to customer service and will include details of how improvements can be made. The training pack created will give practical information on how to deliver customer service to ensure business success.

Learning aim C

This learning aim will be completed with a number of role-play activities or, if a learner is working part-time in customer service, real evidence from their employment can be included in the form of witness statements. Activities and role play will be developed to challenge learners and should include dealing with difficult situations.

For Distinction standard, learners will produce a report after the role-play activities have taken place. The report will give realistic details of how learners need to work on their individual skill sets to enhance their customer service and communication skills. Learners will produce a clear critique, highlighting their strengths and weaknesses. They will have fully embraced the role-play scenarios, demonstrated their skills with confidence and used initiative when dealing with challenging situations.

For Merit standard, learners will produce a clear analytical report showing how their skills should be improved. Participation in customer service situations will have been good with levels of confidence shown across the activities.

For Pass standard, learners will show effective customer service and communication skills in the customer service situations and a realistic plan for addressing weaknesses will have been developed.

Links to other units

This unit links to:

- Unit 1: Exploring Business
- Unit 15: Investigating Retail Business
- Unit 42: Aspects of UK Civil Liability Affecting Business
- Unit 43: Aspects of UK Criminal Law Impacting on Business and Individuals.

Employer involvement

This unit would benefit from employer involvement in the form of:

- guest speakers and interview opportunities
- work experience
- business material as exemplars
- participation in audience assessment of presentations
- visits to appropriate businesses.

Opportunities to develop transferable employability skills

In completing this unit, learners will have the opportunity to develop customer service skills.